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The Legacy

Fears that Bhagat Singh's legacy risked being consigned to oblivion arose almost immediately after Independence. The fears were deep and pronounced. The Congress politician Asaf Ali, who represented Bhagat Singh in the Assembly Bomb Case 1929, in a newspaper article in Pune 1949 expressed his deep concern that Bhagat Singh, who had only until a few years earlier been a 'household name', stood now to just become 'a page of history which has grown dim' and nothing more than an 'obsolescent page' in India's history.[1] Thirty years later, when G.S. Deol came to write his biography in 1978, he was afraid that the essence of Bhagat Singh risked being entirely diluted if he was being seen 'only as freedom fighter' because this was 'to do injustice to the work of this great son of India'.[2] In order to do 'full honour to his work', what was needed, argued Hooja, was detailed research into Bhagat Singh's life and ideas.[3] Ashok Dhawale observes that Bhagat Singh's thought can be compartmentalized into four aspects of revolutionary struggle. These were his 'struggle against imperialism', his 'resistance to communalism and caste oppression', his 'opposition to bourgeois landlord rule', and his belief in 'Marxism and socialism'.[4] And yet, Bhagat Singh is survived today only by his handwritten manifestoes, letters, essays, notes and pamphlets, and much of this, as Moffat points out, which 'as a prisoner between 1929 and 1931 remains contested'.[5]

Bhagat Singh's nephew Jagmohan Singh, the son of his sister Bibi Amar Kaur, has produced the most well-known compilation of Bhagat Singh's writings, statements and letters in a 1982 Punjabi publication by the name of *Bhagat Singh Ate Uhna De Saathian Diyan Likhtaan*[6] ('Bhagat Singh